FLEET TEAM DIGEST

737MAX-FTD-00-24002

Issue Title : MEL Operational Procedures – Dispatch with Multiple MEL Items

Airplane Model	ATA	Minor Model(s)
737MAX	0010-00	-10, -7, -8, -8200, -9, -BBJ
Other Model(s)	**ECCN**	
777, 787, 757, 737NG, 737, 767, 747-400, 777X, 747	9E991	

Originated Date	Last Revised Date	Created On
09/03/2024	09/03/2024	08/14/2024
Estimated Completion Date	**Next Update Date**	
12/27/2024	12/27/2024	

Description

Through our Safety Management System (SMS) process, Boeing has identified two opportunities to reduce safety risk by improving the Master Minimum Equipment List (MMEL) and Dispatch Deviation Guide (DDG) guidance and how the Minimum Equipment List (MEL) is applied by the operator:

1. **Application of incompatible MEL items** may create confusion, which could lead to the potential for an elevated level of risk.
2. **Flight crew procedures may not consider all MEL items applied to the airplane**, leading to actions or inaction potentially resulting in an elevated level of risk.

The purpose of this article is to remind operators about potential risks related to misapplying Minimum Equipment List (MEL) items and to provide suggestions and best practices to mitigate such risks.

Status

Boeing assembled a team of subject matter experts from Dispatch Requirements Engineering, Flight Deck Crew Operations, Airplane Safety Engineering, Chief Mechanic, Tech Pilot, and SMS Focals. The team performed a qualitative analysis of risk level and identified controls to mitigate the severity of the consequences and reduce the likelihood of a related incident. The team outlined above also conducted data analysis to validate risk level and risk reduction actions. The review of Continued Operational Safety Program (COSP) and Aviation Safety Reporting System (ASRS) data shows instances in which misapplication of MELs, along with other factors, may have contributed to an elevated level of risk, potentially including hull loss, and/or regulatory action. Although these incidents have a **very low likelihood** of occurring, they can potentially have *severe consequences* when they do occur. Details related to the control action plan will be published here as they become available.

Interim Action

Possible actions Operators can take to reduce risk are as follows:

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1. **Training**
    1. Ensure there is quality training in operator policies and procedures for applying and managing MEL items for Flight Dispatchers, Maintenance Control Operations personnel, Pilots, Mechanics, and any other areas involved in this process. AC 120-125 provides information for operators to develop and use a minimum equipment list (MEL) and an MEL management program.
2. **Flight Crew Briefing / Crew Awareness**
    1. Ensure that airplane MEL status and information about MEL items applied to the airplane is sufficiently discussed as a part of every crew briefing.
    2. Require the Captain's acknowledgement of MEL status prior to operation of the airplane.
3. **Captain Is the Final Authority**
    1. Ensure that Captain has the ability to accept or reject an airplane. Industry best practice provides that Maintenance Control applies an MEL item, the crew reviews the MEL item, and the Captain has the ability to accept or reject the airplane with those MEL items applied.
4. **Establish process Requiring review of Applicable MELs**
    1. Monitor and review deferrals on a regular basis (industry best practice provides that open MEL items should be reviewed daily).
    2. Audit all MEL items that are currently applied to the airplane to ensure compatibility between the various items and ensure compliance with established MEL policies and procedures.
    3. Monitor and measure quantity of MEL items applied the fleet and the systems impacted. Establishing thresholds for the number of MEL items applied to an airplane can allow for a safe and balanced operation. Having multiple MEL items applied to an airplane can create added risk and an economic impact, while attempting to keep the number of MEL items low can lead to operational delays and/or cancellations.
    4. Establish a process for closing MEL items and avoid keeping MEL items open for their entire interval.
5. **Other Best Practice Suggestions**
    1. Use of MEL should not be the first option. Instead, check if the item can be fixed, and if not, try deferring it . This will help MEL users pinpoint the item needed.
    2. Manage checklists that must be modified to address MMEL.
    3. Limit the number of flight-deck-impacting MELs. Once the limit is exceeded, items should be escalated to the Captain (and/or others) for discussion and review.
    4. MEL items must be well understood before being applied to an airplane. Find answers to any questions that arise during the process, and if in doubt don't apply the MEL item.
6. **Reporting / Just Culture**
    1. Implement a reporting program to close the feedback loop when there are issues or problems with the MELs.
    2. Encourage incident reporting (such as ASRS).
    3. Implement Just Culture – see here for more information about Just Culture: https://www.boeing.com/sustainability/values
7. **Other Support**
    1. Create an internal MEL Stakeholder group. Assign key individuals to be responsible for reviewing their section of each MEL revision.
    2. Attend MMEL Regional Industry Group meetings.
    3. Bring questions and issues to the FAA Flight Operations Evaluation Board (FOEB) for resolution.
    4. AC 120-125 was designed and developed to aid and provide guidance for operators to develop and use an MEL/NEF/CDL program – https://www.faa.gov/regulations_policies/advisory_circulars/index.cfm/go/document.information/documentID/1042238

Final Action

For the Final Action, details will be provided at the next update of this article in 4Q 2024.

Details to be discussed at the MMEL WTT.

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Milestones

The team is planning to have an MMEL WTT November 2024 (date TBD).

Other milestones will be updated by 4Q 2024.

Related Categories

- Flight Operations : Flight Operations

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